The Color of Scars

By Florri McMillan

NOTE: Connie's narration to the audience is clear and precise. Her interactions with other characters should demonstrate the aphasia she is experiencing.

INTRODUCTION

A stroke can happen to anyone at any time. Blood flow to an area of the brain is cut off; brain cells are deprived of oxygen and begin to die. Each year nearly 800,000 people experience a stroke of some type. In this selection, Connie is one of those people. At the age of 34, she has experienced a stroke strong enough to damage the part of her brain that controls language. This condition is called aphasia – Connie is trapped within her own mind, with the ability to form coherent thoughts, but with no means to express them to those around her. This is The Color of Scars by Florrie McMillan.

DOCTOR: Close your eyes, Constance, and keep them closed

CONNIE: I obey, but my ears cling to the tiny nylon crackles of her uniform. White blots explode-angry spurting flashes against a humming in my brain. Flakes of snow dance flat on a black square; a television set is broken or left on all night, abandoned by the sleeper.

DOCTOR: Open your eyes, Constance, and keep them open. *(Into a tape recorder)* This is a thirty-four year old white female ... *(To Connie)* How many fingers?

CONNIE: *(unintelligible response)*

DOCTOR: Do you know what day this is?

CONNIE: *(unintelligible response)* He purses his fat lips into a pink "O", as if he has expected this disappointment.

DOCTOR: What color is this? *(holding out the tape recorder)*

CONNIE: *(to audience)* But I do not know what color is. Dr. Francesca nonchalantly squeezes my hand. He studies my face and his eyes are turning black. From their cold depths he searches, listening and probing, for a chink in

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death, one thin shaft of light. A colorless heat has risen in my brain, spraying little electric bursts that burn out as quickly as they come. *(loud cries and unintelligible animal sounds)* Charred fumes trickle from my lips; sounds I have never heard. I can smell the residue of rage. All the people in the room are backing away from my bed with horrified eyes, seeking protection in the soft vanilla walls.

DOCTOR: She can't help the shouting. She hardly knows she does it. All short circuits up here, you see *(pointing to her temple)* She is afraid too, maybe.

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CONNIE: Mother is allowed to see me for five minutes of each hour. One morning I try to find out what happened. She flutters around the end of the bed, telling me there was a seizure – [a fit, she says]. "What's the matter?" I ask *(unintelligible sounds)*, and she keeps right on talking about how I cannot talk quite, can't understand always, and the artery is broken, yes, deep in there. "Why aren't I dead," I say. *(unintelligible sounds)* She explains there is a blob of blood, like jello, around the break, covering it over a little. She doesn't know what will happen if the jello melts; yes she supposes it *will* melt, but not before the operation, she hopes. Her voice is sparrow cheerful, but she picks at the corners of my tucked in blanket, her fingers darting like delicate claws over the wool.

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CONNIE: [After weeks of tests and assessments] they push machines around and arrange my limbs with straps. They [are] going to shoot dye into my brain and take an X-ray. Then we'd know. "Know what?" I asked him. *(unintelligible sounds)*

DOCTOR: Don't be afraid.

CONNIE: But he [is] afraid. Everyone in this room is afraid. Dr. Francesca stands

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close to my head, looking at me. Deliberately I meet his eyes.

DOCTOR: *(encouringly as he injects the dye)* You can stand anything for four seconds.

CONNIE: *(In words and pantomime)* I slam rigid into the pain, shooting upward so hard my teeth fuse into my skull; and it crumples, a steel hull destroyed entirely. Its fragments float by, washed away in turquoise. The color is everywhere, so intense that it obliterates me: the I, the eyes, all things, nothing, nothing exists except the color turquoise . . . [and then] I am lying calm in light. There is no weight or color to the air. Water has no ripples. My brain holds no pattern . . . [Dr. Francesca] breaks through the swinging door. He holds the wet, black square of the X-ray high, in triumph.

DOCTOR: Now I know where it is. Put your index finger on your nose and put the other finger in your ear. Extend the lines until they meet. That's where it is. . . It's a bad place.

CONNIE: *(to audience)* I know it is in a bad place. The neurologists have explained that I say "Thursday Thursday Thursday Thursday Thursday Thursday Thursday," instead of the days of the week. At ten in the morning I can talk to Mother. By dark I can only make the hard sounds. "Kick," I can say. Kick, like bones cracking. Most other words are gone, not there anymore. Color is gone. Where are the words? What color is Thursday?

DOCTOR: We'll go in here *(indicating a spot on Connie's temple)* And clip here and then ... here *(indicating two additional locations on Connie's head)* and hope we can get the thing out without removing too much of the brain.

CONNIE: His eyes are sad when he begins, touching the points where the burl of the electric drill will enter, but by the time he has completed the pattern, they glitter with the hard reflection of challenge.

DOCTOR: I'm confident about this. I'm confident.

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CONNIE: He is watching me closely. My head aches with the effort to find a word. I know that I can say kick, kick. "Talk." I say it twice, and Francesca understands. He looks at me without moving for a long time. I wait for an answer.

DOCTOR: You want to go with this operation?

CONNIE: Talk?

DOCTOR: Alive is everything.

CONNIE: *(Struggling with the word)* Go

DOCTOR: This Thursday, then.

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CONNIE: In the dark I hide from Death. I lie very quietly, as wild birds and beggars do, to avoid detection, to be not sufficiently interesting to her. My eyes are always open, spreading wide to find light. It is always black, empty. I am always alone. I stare for days until white begins to flow into my eye sockets, stuffing the holes until it chokes me. I open my mouth to push it back and . . . *(scream, again and again in abject fear)* Someone is shouting. The rough edges of the voice rip small holes in the black around me. The barked commands tear the darkness into lacy, floating shreds. Beyond them is the Devil's face, surrounded by a ring of light. Dark eyes are glittering. Lips stretch wide against white, flashing teeth. I hear Him laughing, piercing the black with rising, unearthly sound, and then I recognize Dr. Francesca, who has cut his deal-alive is everything

DOCTOR: *(shouting)* Squeeze my fingers! Squeeze my fingers!

CONNIE: *(in words and pantomime)* And I reach up to them and grab his hand. *(laughter at the accomplishment)* Alive is everything.

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CONNIE: The color of pain is the winter sky, no end and no beginning. The muscles

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deep in the pit of my stomach are clenched all the time, so tight I cannot make any sound. If I move, the pain will never end. *(In obvious pain and in words and pantomime)* I lift the top of the tray that swings across my bed. There is a steel mirror underneath. I have not looked at myself since the operation. I expect to see the marks of prolonged pain: ravaged eyes and deep lines around the mouth. I can't take my eyes off my head. There is a wide flat shelf on the right side. And a hole. There is a deep hole the size of a Kennedy half dollar in my head. A thin layer of shiny skin is sucked down into it. I close my eyes, but I do not cry.

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CONNIE: When it is clear to everyone that I am not going to die, they hire Sheila, an R.N. who works at the Rehabilitation Institute across the street. Sheila has special training in physical medicine – [she] nurses people who are too sick for therapy, sort of warming them up for rehabilitation. She won't give me coffee until I walk over to the chair. She asks me questions as long as I can talk. Then, when I am tired, she reads the newspaper out loud. Sheila usually asks me who the people are in the newspaper pictures, but I never recognize any of them. This used to irritate me, but now, sometimes, it makes me feel like weeping. Sheila says I am getting much better, that almost everything I say before lunch makes sense. We name things together. [Bed, newspaper, mirror, light] She is very pleased. She calls the tiny marks on the newspaper "letters." I don't understand letters. Can I make some? she asks, giving me a paper and a pen. Suddenly my fingers are frozen. I can't move them.

When Sheila picks up her pad of paper and the pen it is close to the end of her shift. One afternoon I understand something. "You're writing," I say,

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and she looks very pleased. It is suddenly clear that the newspaper is "reading." I look at my fingers and say, "I can't write." And I can't read- names or newspapers. I don't know pictures or faces. I won't be able to learn to write, read, which is which. *(quietly)* "I can't talk."

********* [The next day Dr. Francesca confronts me] *********

DOCTOR: *(angrily)* Sheila says you won't talk.

CONNIE: His eyes, deep in the sockets, are ignited like live, black coals.

DOCTOR: You can talk.

CONNIE: I stare back, helpless. *(to the Doctor)* Cat

DOCTOR: Yes you can.

CONNIE: *(shaking her head)* Cat.

DOCTOR: Try harder.

CONNIE: *(shouting and crying)* Cat! CAT CAT CAT *(to audience)* It is so hard to say it. I am panting.

DOCTOR: Can't.

CONNIE: *(softly, exhausted)* Can't. The water is tickling my cheeks. It is covering softly, not quite warm, washing the dirt from my eye sockets. I can see the blackness receding, flaking away and dripping with the water, out of sight. It rises in my head and then empties itself, until the darkness is washed away.

DOCTOR: Why are you crying?

CONNIE: *(speaking haltingly, but clearly for the first time as she wraps her hands around her head)* I'm afraid . . . I am afraid. I can't read or write. I can't talk.

DOCTOR: *(Peeling her fingers away from her scalp and looking directly into her eyes – moving his fingers over the indentions in her head)* You're a living miracle.

CONNIE: *(looking up)* You did that before. With a red pencil, your finger.

DOCTOR: You remember that? *(He fits the ball of his thumb into the hole and presses*

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against the skin.) It doesn't matter what you lost. It's healed now.

CONNIE: [And] I can feel it, feel the edges of my skull soften.

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CONNIE: Fourteen is not the same as the other floors. Everyone has the same horseshoe-shaped wound on one side of the head, a tribal scar which can never be rubbed out. When I move carefully along the corridor I can see, in 1487, a tiny, shriveled woman with fingers curved into bird claws, so old that her flesh, veined like onion skin, clings tight to the outlines of her skull. A thin ribbon is tied around her scar and a few white tufts on the unshaven side of her head.

Next door there is a handsome boy about eighteen with a stubble growth of beard beginning. The white of his scar glows through his dark brown crew cut. Sheila told me he had a football injury. My eyes met his, but there is no flicker of response. Sheila says he is fine except that he can't walk.

The retarded boy in 1462, next to me, cries all the time. Sometimes his noises are like moaning, other times he sounds like angry, jabbering crows outside a window. Often, in the night, he heaves dry sobs, without tears, until he falls asleep. He has had an operation to relieve his pain. Today he is calling out to someone unnamed in a language no one understands.

(In words and pantomime) I stop in sunlight to examine my fingers. I riffle them like a child playing a hand game, and it seems to me wonderful that I can do this. I lift them slowly, one at a time in sequence and I see the old lady raising her white, fluttering fingers over a piano keyboard; the retarded boy behind a podium, speaking clearly and forcefully; the

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quarterback cutting down the sideline, dancing out his dream. Moving the fingers of my good working hand, I weep.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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